

Interstellar Labs — People & Culture Handbook

Internal knowledge base · Last updated: June 2026 · Document owner: Operations / People

Summary handbook for the team. Sample data for demo/knowledge-base purposes; not a contract of employment.

How we work

Interstellar Labs is **remote-first** with regional hubs in Milton Keynes (UK HQ) and San Francisco (US). You can work from home, from a hub, or from a co-working space we sponsor.

- **Core collaboration hours:** 13:00–17:00 UK time, so UK and US teams overlap daily.
- **Async by default:** Decisions are written down. We favour clear docs and short Looms over long meetings.
- **Meeting-light:** Wednesdays are no-internal-meeting days for deep work.

Working hours & location

- Standard week is **37.5 hours**, flexible around core hours.
- US-based team members follow Pacific Time but keep the shared core overlap.
- Equipment: company laptop plus a **£/\$1,000 home-office setup budget** in year one.

Time off

- **Annual leave: 28 days** paid time off per year, plus public holidays for your country (UK or US).
- **Carryover:** Up to 5 unused days roll into the next year; the rest expire.
- **Sick leave:** Up to 10 paid sick days per year; longer absences handled case by case.
- **Parental leave:** 16 weeks fully paid for the primary caregiver; 6 weeks for the secondary caregiver.
- **Company recharge:** The company closes for one week at the end of December (not counted against leave).
- **Booking time off:** Request via the HR tool at least 2 weeks ahead for planned leave; manager approval is usually same-day.

Benefits

- **Private health cover** (UK: Vitality-style plan; US: medical/dental/vision).
- **Pension / 401(k):** UK pension with employer match up to 5%; US 401(k) with 4% match.
- **Learning budget:** \$1,200 per person per year for courses, books, and conferences.

- **CodeWithChuka access:** Free Pro access to our own learning platform when it launches.
- **Wellbeing stipend:** \$50/month toward fitness or wellness.

Pay & reviews

- Salaries are benchmarked to role and region and reviewed **twice a year** (April and October).
- Transparent banding: each role maps to a published level (L1–L6).
- Promotions are decoupled from reviews and can happen any cycle.

Onboarding (first two weeks)

1. **Day 1:** Accounts, laptop, buddy assigned, read the company handbook set.
2. **Week 1:** Ship a small change to production; meet each team.
3. **Week 2:** Own a scoped task end to end; first 1:1 with your manager.

New joiners get a **30/60/90-day plan** agreed with their manager.

Conduct & expectations

- Treat colleagues, customers, and partners with respect. Harassment or discrimination is not tolerated.
- Protect customer data; follow the security practices in the Support & SLA document.
- Conflicts of interest (including outside work) must be disclosed to Operations.
- Use of company AI tools must follow our responsible-AI guidelines (no customer data in untrusted tools).

Expenses

- Reasonable work expenses are reimbursed within 10 business days of an approved claim.
- Travel between hubs for team meet-ups is company-funded and booked through Operations.

Who to ask

- **People / HR questions:** people@interstellarlabs.company
- **IT / equipment:** it@interstellarlabs.company
- **Anything else:** your manager or your onboarding buddy